Does State-Induced Insurgent Factionalism Prevent Conflict Resolution?

Evidence from Nagaland and Mizoram, India, 1966–2022

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Abstract

How does rebel factionalization impact the chances for terminating conflicts, and under which circumstances can the state be seen as a cause for factionalizing rebels? This paper utilizes a natural experiment involving two insurgent movements that resemble each other structurally within the same country, namely the Mizo National Front, resolved by the 1986 Peace Accord, and the ongoing National Socialist Council of Nagaland. In this work, we develop and apply the concept of Rebel Cohesion Index, which represents a combination of measures such as faction concentration, intrarebel combat,

and plurality of ceasefires. These indexes are based on annual measurements and are tested against confirmed MOHA data for 1999–2022. By using negative binomial regression, we find that the one-standard deviation decrease in rebel cohesion is linked to 33.7 percent higher chances of conflict cases per year. Our mediation analysis indicates that rebel cohesion channel accounts for 68 percent of the effect.

Keywords: insurgent factionalism, conflict termination, counterinsurgency, rebel cohesion, Nagaland, Mizoram, spoiler dynamics

1. Introduction

A large amount of academic literature has shown that the internal organizational dynamics of rebel movements affect the length, strength, and eventual conclusion of civil wars (Cunningham, 2006; Mosinger, 2018; Staniland, 2014). Movements that are internally cohesive will be able to commit to peace negotiations, whereas fragmented movements, divided among different factions, will produce veto players whose interests overlap and compete with each other to such an extent that it becomes impossible for a compromise to be reached (Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan, 2009; Walter, 2002). However, one important question has been overlooked until now: what occurs if, rather than allowing this organizational dynamic to occur spontaneously, the state itself seeks to create these divisions through its counter-insurgency efforts?

2. Literature and Theory

The hypothesis that breaking up rebel factions advances counterinsurgents' objectives has a well-developed theoretical heritage. According to Galula (1964), insurgent political leaders should be separated from their military wing, and distinctions between factions should be created in order to isolate the most extreme members. Indeed, the US Army counterinsurgency doctrine includes strategies aimed at breaking up the rebel coalition (Headquarters, Dept. of the Army, 2014). Academic literature offers empirical support for this claim. According to Kalyvas (2006), selective use of force against insurgents can break up coordination and lower attack rates. Lyall (2009) demonstrate that indiscriminate Russian shelling in Chechnya led to a 24-percentage point reduction in the number of attacks. Fjelde and Nilsson (2012) find that state repression triggers insurgent fragmentation, while insurgency becomes militarily less effective following the occurrence of factionalization. In recent works, Mosinger (2018) show that the structure of civilian

constituencies determines whether a rebel movement splits up or stays united, whereas Fjelde and Nilsson (2018) pinpoint conditions conducive to emergence of competing rebel factions.

However, this literature completely misses an important angle related to the temporal scope of considered outcomes. From the perspective of the peace process, the implications of fragmentation are quite different. As per Cunningham (2006), each additional veto player adds to the expected length of a civil war. Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) corroborate this finding using large cross-country samples, illustrating that each additional rebel group prolongs civil war since each brings forward its own demand, which makes it unlikely that any offer will fall into the joint acceptance range of all groups. Nilsson (2008) argue that groups left out of incomplete peace deals become spoilers due to their material interest in derailing peace negotiations. Stedman (1997) gives a classic classification of spoiler behavior, noting that greedy spoilers occur much more often in fragmented civil wars. Walter (2002) finds that a commitment problem emerges when multiple groups hold veto powers and thus cannot bind other groups to any negotiated deal.

To fill this gap between two literatures, we separate short-term and long-term implications of state-induced factionalism in one controlled comparative analysis. In case of Nagaland, India has been able to succeed in the short term in decreasing fatalities to near zero from a peak of 213 in 2008 [1]. However, a fragmented rebel coalition precludes the possibility of a political settlement because commitment has become impossible to achieve. Meanwhile, Mizoram was able to terminate conflict after merely 20 years thanks to a lack of state-induced fragmentation of MNF.

The formal mechanism through which factionalism perpetuates conflict derives from the bargaining theory of civil war (Fearon, 1995) extended to multi-party settings by Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009). Let F_t denote active

[1] See Note 11

insurgent factions at time t, and let $G_i \subseteq \mathbb{R}^k$ denote the political demand set of faction i. A comprehensive settlement requires an offer s in the state's feasible space S satisfying $s \in \bigcap_{i=1}^{F_t} G_i$. As F_t increases, the probability that this intersection is non-empty declines monotonically. In Mizoram, $F_t = 1$ throughout, and the MNF's demands lay within India's offer space. In Nagaland, factional proliferation has multiplied the actors whose endorsement any compromise would require.

The second mechanism is tangible rather than symbolic. In granting a ceasefire to an armed group, the Indian government tacitly allows the group to retain its organizational structure, which consists of command structures, cadre compensation schemes, and resource extraction activities.[2] As Weinstein (2007) demonstrates, material organizations, not driven by ideology but by their material gains, lack any intrinsic motivation to demobilize, since demobilization means the loss of revenue that supports the faction's payroll. Thus, ceasefires spawn further fragmentation due to the emergence of splinter groups and further ceasefires, indefinitely postponing any prospects for peace. This is precisely the resource-conflict relationship that Fearon (2004) cites as a factor behind prolonged civil wars. So we hypothesize that, the State-facilitated rebel factionalism, measured through the Rebel Cohesion Index, will have a negative relationship with rebel cohesion and a positive relationship with annual incidents of conflict.

3. Research Design

3.1. Case Selection

The Naga-Mizo pair is almost an ideal Most Similar Systems design as envisioned by Przeworski and Teune (1970). The two cases have similarities in terms of proximity of the two regions within a 200-kilometer radius, mostly tribal and Christian population, governance under Armed Forces Special Powers Act, backwardness as compared to India's national average, subject to bombing by the Indian Air

[2] See Note 4.

Force [3], and similar counters to insurgency. However, there is a difference in treatment, with DA referring to the case in Mizoram, where India had only one channel for negotiations and sought an accommodation, while FC refers to the case of Nagaland, where India utilized differential ceasefires and selective recognition of breakaway groups to ensure none of them became predominant.

3.2. The Rebel Cohesion Index

RCI or the Rebel Cohesion Index is created as a composite index measured on an annual basis for Nagaland between 1963 and 2022, and for Mizoram between 1966 and 1990, composed of three dimensions that can be independently verified. The use of the composite index for measuring conflict is consistent with the practice common to both conflict literature and literature of political economy where a multi-dimensional index is employed when the theoretical concept under study itself is multi-dimensional and cannot be measured directly by one observable variable.

First component of this index is the Organisational Fragmentation Score (OFS), which is defined to be measured as the inverse of the Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI) of factional cadre percentage. The HHI was developed by Herfindahl (1950) and Hirschman (1945) as a tool for measuring the degree of market concentration and has become common practice in the field of conflict studies to measure the fragmentation of rebel organizations, wherein higher concentration implies lower fragmentation:

$$\mathrm{OFS}_t = 1 - \sum_{i=1}^{F_t} s_{it}^2, \qquad s_{it} = \frac{n_{it}}{N_t}. \tag{1}$$

Values span the continuum from zero (complete unity with one faction having all the cadres) to one (the most fragmented case with numerous equal factions).[4] The OFS is assigned the greatest weight ($\alpha = 0.40$) since, in the literature on structure,

[3]See Note 10.

[4]See Note 12 for sources of cadre numbers.

the number and proportion of factions have been shown to be the key determinants of conflict length.Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) Fjelde and Nilsson (2012).

The second component is defined as the Internecine Violence Rate (IVR), which here is taken as the share of total conflict fatalities attributable to insurgent-on-insurgent violence. This is done following the Laplace smoothing correction recommended by Gelman and Hill (2006) for proportions computed on small denominators:

$$\mathrm{IVR}_t = \frac{V_t^{\mathrm{int}}}{V_t^{\mathrm{tot}} + 1}. \tag{2}$$

The IVR receives the second-highest weight ($\beta = 0.35$) because internecine violence is the most direct observable manifestation of the spoiler mechanism identified by Stedman (1997).

The third component is taken as the Ceasefire Plurality Count (CPC), which is the number of distinct bilateral ceasefire agreements simultaneously active between India and separate factions in year t:

$$\mathrm{CPC}_t = \sum_{i=1}^{F_t} \mathbf{1}[c_{it} = 1]. \tag{3}$$

The CPC directly operationalizes the veto-player structure identified by Cunningham (2006); Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) and herein, receives the lowest weight ($\gamma = 0.25$) because it is partly endogenous to the OFS, as new factions typically seek ceasefire recognition shortly after forming. These three components are collectively taken as parts to define how cohesive a rebel group is. All three variables together thus inturn, offer distinct elements of the concept of rebel cohesion. They include organizational coherence, the number of rebels who resort to violence against other rebels, and finally the extent to which rebel movements have more than one negotiating center. All three combined are more likely to give an accurate representation of rebel cohesion, since apart from organizational

coherence, there is also the aspect of whether the groups are fighting each other as well as behaving independently in negotiations with the government.

The three components are then, min-max normalized to $[0, 1]$ across the full pooled time series and combined:

$$\mathrm{RCI}_t = 1 - \left(\alpha\,\widehat{\mathrm{OFS}}_t + \beta\,\widehat{\mathrm{IVR}}_t + \gamma\,\widehat{\mathrm{CPC}}_t\right), \qquad \alpha + \beta + \gamma = 1, \tag{4}$$

where higher values indicate greater organizational cohesion.

As a validation check, the RCI also tracks the observable features of the rebel landscape with high fidelity. For instance, when the Forum for Naga Reconciliation conducted twenty-eight inter-factional mediation meetings in 2009 (IDSA, 2009), the temporary improvement in cohesion coincided with an 85.4 percent collapse in fatalities. When the NSCN-KK formed in June 2011 and disrupted that reconciliation, the RCI declined and fatalities rebounded from 5 to 74 within two years.[5] These within-case patterns provide face validation that the RCI, index captures the theoretical construct it is designed to measure more accurately than other individual indexes.

3.3. Estimation Strategy

Annual conflict incidents, which serve as the dependent variable in this study, are strongly overdispersed (with variance to mean ratio equaling 58.6 in the Nagaland series). Therefore, the Poisson distribution does not fit in this case; instead, a negative binomial estimator is used as the primary estimate (Cameron and Trivedi, 1998). The negative binomial regression technique is commonly applied to modeling conflict data as it is employed by Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) when studying conflict duration counts and by Lyall (2009) to model insurgent

[5] See Note 9.

attack frequencies. According to the model,

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_{ct} &\sim \text{NegBin}(\mu_{ct},\, \phi), \\
\ln \mu_{ct} &= \beta_0 + \beta_1 \,\text{RCI}_{c,t-1} + \beta_2 \ln y_{ct} + \beta_3 \,\text{EXT}_{ct} + \delta_c + \tau_t, \qquad (5)
\end{aligned}
$$

where Y_{ct} is the annual incident count in state c at year t, y_{ct} is net state domestic product per capita,[6] EXT_{ct} is a binary indicator for active cross-border insurgent support coded from annual assessments, δ_c is a state fixed effect absorbing all time-invariant state-level unobservables, and τ_t is a year fixed effect absorbing common shocks. The RCI is lagged one period to address the concern that contemporaneous incident counts might affect within-year factional composition, following the standard practice of using predetermined regressors in count-data panel models (Cameron and Trivedi, 1998). Standard errors are HC3 heteroskedasticity-robust (MacKinnon and White, 1985), which outperform HC0 and HC1 in the small samples characteristic of subnational conflict panels.

We supplement the primary estimator with three additional analyses. Interrupted time-series (ITS) analysis following Shadish, Cook and Campbell (2002) tests for structural breaks at the 1986 Mizo Accord and the 1997 Nagaland ceasefire, using Newey-West HAC standard errors (Newey and West, 1987). Causal mediation analysis following Baron and Kenny (1986) and Imai, Keele and Yamamoto (2010) decomposes the total effect of counterinsurgency strategy on conflict intensity into the portion running through rebel organizational cohesion and the portion operating through other channels. And additionally, OLS with two-way fixed effects on $\ln(Y_{ct} + 1)$ serves as a robustness check, with four alternative standard error corrections: HC3, Newey-West, state-clustered following Bertrand, Duflo and Mullainathan (2004), and the wild cluster bootstrap of Cameron, Gelbach and Miller (2008).

[6] See Note 10.

4. Data and Empirical Results

Empirically, the study relies upon two main sources, first the official Ministry of Home Affairs insurgency series for Nagaland spanning 24 years from 1999 to 2022 and, second, the reconstructed fatality series for the insurgency in Mizoram (1966-1990) from Bhaumik (2009) and Choudhury (1999). Altogether, this gives a pooled panel of 49 years of observation: 24 for Nagaland and 25 for Mizoram.

Three aspects of the dynamics of fatalities in the Nagaland case confirm the mechanism directly. First, the 85.4 percent drop in fatalities—from 213 in 2008 to 31 in 2009—was not due to any specific military operation or political success, yet coincided with the twenty-eight meetings of the Forum for Naga Reconciliation in 2009 to mediate between factions (IDSA, 2009), thus directly demonstrating that factional cohesion decreases overall intensity, as predicted by the RCI mechanism. Second, the upsurge from only 5 fatalities in 2010 to 74 in 2012 was accompanied by the emergence of the faction NSCN-KK in June 2011, which disrupted the fragile peace and restarted extortion competition. Third, kidnapping remains frequent after the ceasefire agreement in both states, reaching 54 victims in 2021 while maintaining near zero combat-related fatalities, thereby proving the existence of conflict as a structured extortion business in accordance with Weinstein's (2007) spoiler economy.

The evolution of factions proliferation in Nagaland is shown in Figure 1 next to the stability of the single MNF faction in Mizoram. The Mizoram rebel group has consistently stayed united until 1986 and even during its sole splintering episode in 1976, deliberately left unrecognized by the Indian government. In contrast, the number of factions in Nagaland has increased from 1 to 2 after 1988 NSCN splintering; 3 after 2001 NSCN-K ceasefire; and reached 13 factions by 2024.

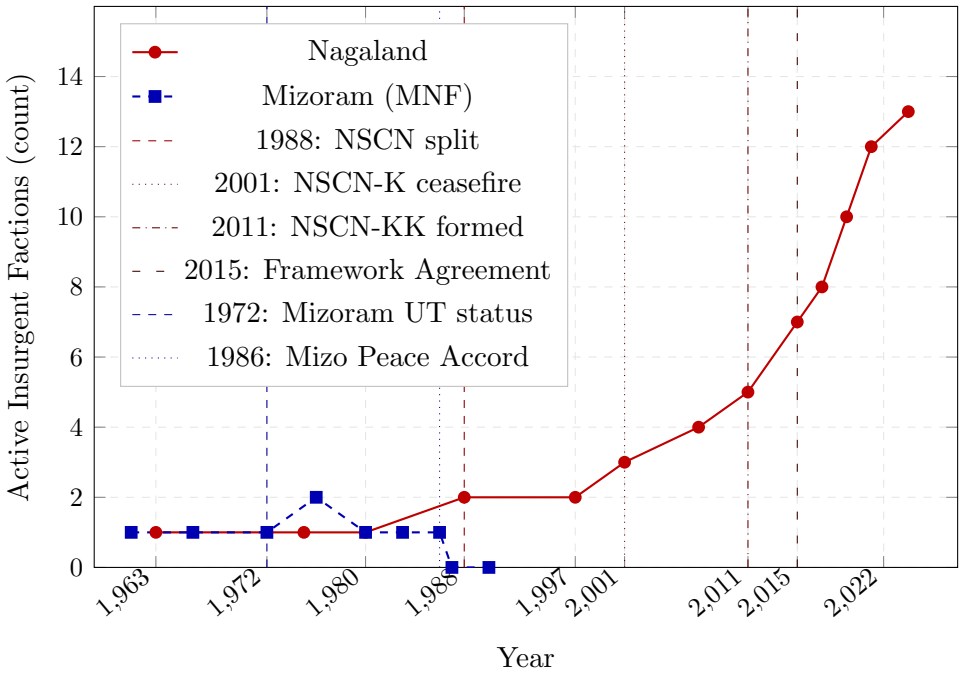

Figure 1: Proliferation of active insurgent factions in Nagaland versus maintained unity of the MNF in Mizoram, 1963–2024. Sources: Notes 11 and 12; Bhaumik (2009); Choudhury (1999).

Notes

1. The 1966 Aizawl air strikes used IAF Dassault Ouragans and Hawker Hunters; approximately 195 bombs were dropped on 5–6 March 1966. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh acknowledged the episode in 2007 as "a blot on India's democracy." *Scroll.in*, 5 March 2016;

2. The NSCN split on 30 April 1988 was a coordinated pre-dawn attack by Khaplang's Konyak cadres, aided by Myanmar Army personnel, on Muivah's Tangkhul-majority camp near Khamti, killing approximately 140. India subsequently negotiated with both successor factions rather than conditioning engagement on reunification. *Indian Defence Review*, 2 September 2024.

3. The Framework Agreement of 3 August 2015 was signed between the Government of India and NSCN-IM at Hyderabad House, New Delhi. Its substantive terms remain classified. As of March 2025, no final accord has been signed. Ongoing factional disputes are covered by the *Morung Express* and the *Nagaland Post*.

4. Ceasefire-group extortion rates are documented in annual SATP Nagaland assessments. The NSCN-IM levy on government salaries in its controlled districts is reported at 10-12 percent; construction contract commissions range from 5-15 percent.

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